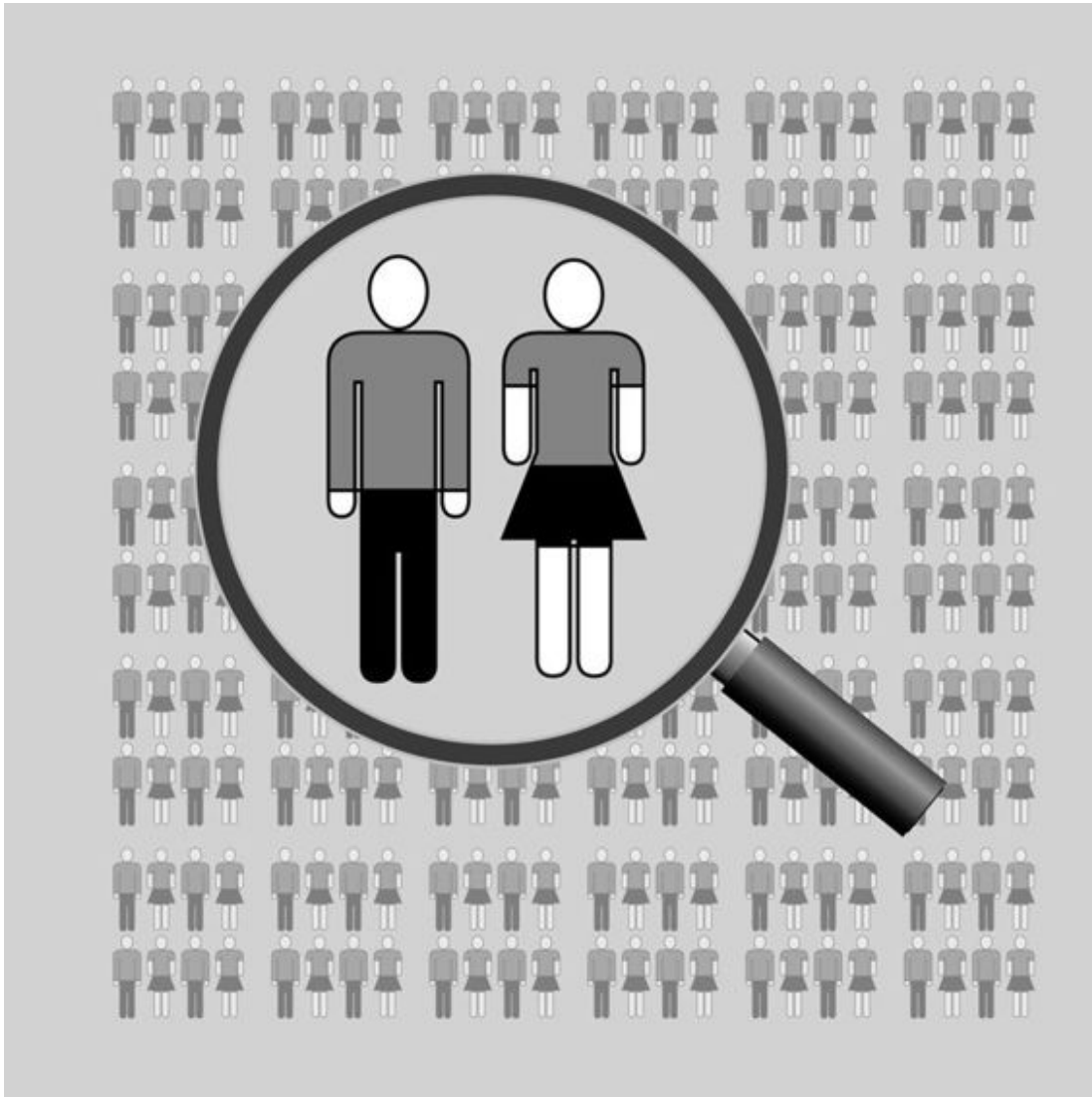


Sociological positivism



Positivism (see [Positivism](#)) proposed that only scientifically verifiable knowledge could be considered valid. This, according to Auguste Comte, not only applied to the natural sciences, but was also a valid principle in considering human social behaviour. Comte argued that society operates according to discoverable laws, in the same way that the physical world is subject to physical laws, and we cannot gain knowledge of society from subjective introspection or intuition, but only through objective scientific study. This idea was the basis of the modern discipline of sociology, and influenced the sociologist Emile Durkheim in the late 19th century to give

the subject an even more scientific footing through practical research. Comte was also influential in the foundation of other social sciences, including anthropology, economics and political science. And although Karl Marx rejected Comte's sociological positivism as such, he shared the view that metaphysical philosophizing was irrelevant to the modern world and that theories in the social sciences should be justified using scientific methods.